

Chandigarh

Location India

The city of Chandigarh was created in the 1950s as the capital of the states of Punjab and Haryana. It was a monument not just to the optimism of a newly independent India, but also to the vision of the man who led the team that built it, the Swiss-French architect Le Corbusier. It was the great opportunity that this pioneer of modern architecture had been waiting for: the creation, from scratch, of an ideal city that was at once harmonious, rational, and bold. Chandigarh's three largest and most important buildings—the High Court of Justice, the Secretariat, and the Palace of Assembly, built between 1951 and 1962, all in raw concrete—are astonishingly original, with a sculptural dynamism that consistently surprises.

Jean-Marie Tjibaou Cultural Center

Location New Caledonia

The Jean-Marie Tjibaou Cultural Center in the former French colony of New Caledonia is not just a remarkable tribute to the Kanak people of the island but an act of contrition on the part of the French government for its treatment of them. It is named after a staunch campaigner for Kanak rights who was assassinated in 1989. It was designed by Italian architect Renzo Piano and completed in 1998. Essentially, it features a radical reworking of traditional Kanak conical huts on a much larger scale. A total of 10 pavilions, each up to 92 ft (28m) high, are arranged in three groups, or “villages,” along a central alley. The organic structures swell

outward but are left only half-built. As a result, they have an almost dematerialized quality, greatly enhanced by their oceanside setting. They contain permanent displays of Kanak life and culture.

Beijing National Stadium

Location Beijing, China

Better known, for obvious reasons, as the Bird's Nest, this stadium was the principal venue of the 2008 Beijing Olympics. Designed by Swiss architects Jacques Herzog and Pierre de Meuron and several Chinese architects, it was completed in 2007. It is, in fact, two separate structures. A more or less conventional, albeit substantial, concrete stadium that

▼ THE INTERLOCKING STEEL GIRDERS OF THE BEIJING NATIONAL STADIUM

seats more than 80,000 people is contained within an elaborate, seemingly random network of interlocking steel girders—part structural, part decorative—that rise at each end. These give the stadium a distinctive, saddle-shaped profile. Laid end to end, the girders would stretch 22.5 miles (36km). It was a solution that proved not just cost-effective but architecturally dramatic, producing the most memorable Olympic stadium since that used at Munich in 1972.

Liyuan Library

Location Jiaojiehe, China

At first sight, the Liyuan Library, situated in the woods outside a small town 50 miles (80km) north of Beijing, is unpromising: a dark, modest, single-story rectangle covering about 1,880 square ft (175 square m). However, closer

